



How to Change a Colostomy Bag

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If you have a colostomy bag, it can take a while to master the skill of changing it. The nurse will have given you instructions on the proper procedure to change the colostomy bag. With time and practice, you will soon become proficient at changing your colostomy bag.

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Part 1

Changing Your Colostomy Bag

^[1] The best place to do this is in the bathroom.

- 1 Wash your hands thoroughly using soap and water.** If this is not possible, use antibacterial hand sanitizer instead.^[2] Place a clean under the bag to protect clothing. Proper hygiene is important when changing a colostomy bag.
- 2 Gently take the pouch off.** Holding the skin with one hand, slowly ease the pouch off using the built in tab for easier removal.
- 3 Check the skin.**^[3] The stoma skin may be a little pink or red. However, if it is black, purple, or blue, or looks concerning to you, call the NCFL nurse or see a medical professional for advice. Also check the stoma in general — stoma should always be beefy red in color, never dark or black. If it is changing in size, going further into or out of your skin, leaking pus or blood, or looks pale or bluish, contact the NCFL nurse and the doctor immediately.
- 4 Clean the stoma.** Using warm water and a dry wipe with mild soap on it, gently wipe around the stoma. Do not rub.^[4] Only use soaps that do not contain any oils or fragrances. Use a dry wipe to pat the skin dry.
 - If necessary, use a measuring card device (given to you by the doctor or nurse) to measure the size of the stoma. You will need to know its size, if you don't already, before attaching a new colostomy bag.^[5]
 - Also be sure to wash your hands one more time before putting on the new pouch. This will ensure optimum sanitization of the new pouch, as you will not want any contamination with old fecal matter.
- 5 Use a skin barrier, such as stoma powder.** It is used as a means to not only protect the skin but also to provide the perfect base for the new colostomy bag to adhere to. Sprinkle stoma powder around the stoma. Be careful not to put the powder on the stoma itself. Carefully dust it around using a dry wipe, and let the area dry for about 60 seconds.
- 6 Prepare the new pouch.** The stoma pouch wafer may need to be modified to fit the stoma properly. If this is the case, use special scissors to cut out the circle on the wafer.^[6]
 - The circle should be approximately 1/8 of an inch larger than the stoma itself. Some wafers have pre-printed guides to help you with this task.
 - Cut the wafer to fit the stoma.
 - This is a process that takes time to master. On-call nurses can answer questions or help solve problems and/or decide if the client needs to be seen or if the problem can be solved with phone consultation.
- 7 Place the wafer over the stoma.** Begin pressing on the part of the flange located underneath the stoma, gently moving to the sides and then to the top. Once adhered, begin smoothing the flange to remove the creases. Doing this helps to form a tighter seal around the stoma.^[7]

- Start in the center (near the stoma) and then move toward the outer edges. All creases must be smoothed; otherwise, the colostomy bag could leak.
- When you change the wafer you will need to use the stoma paste
- Hold the flange for about 45 seconds. The warmth of your hands helps the adhesive stick to the skin.

Part 2

Preparing the Procedure

1 Know when to change the colostomy bag. The frequency with which you need to change it is patient-specific and may depend on which type of bag you are using.^[8] For people with one-piece pouches, the entire colostomy bag will need to be changed each time; on the other hand, for people with two-piece pouches, the pouch itself can be changed as frequently as one desires, while the wafer will only need to be changed every two to three days.

- You should never go longer than seven days between changing of the colostomy bag and appliance.
- Note that this is just a guideline. Always follow the specific instructions from the doctor or nurse as to how frequently to change your colostomy bag.

2 Obtain the proper equipment.

- Be sure that you have plenty of supplies stored, so that you will not find yourself short-handed equipment-wise when you go to change the colostomy bag.

3 Remove the shirt and gather your supplies. Remove the shirt to keep it from getting in your way while you are changing the colostomy bag. Before you begin, make sure all of your supplies are within easy reach.^[9] Supplies generally include:

- A new pouch
- A clean towel
- A small garbage bag
- Skin wipes or cleaning supplies
- Scissors
- A measuring card and pen
- A skin barrier such as stoma powder
- Adhesive material, normally stoma paste
- A new wafer, in case needed

Community Q&A

Question

What should I do if I'm bleeding from the rectum?

Community Answer

Go to the ER. Blood coming from the rectum is a definite sign of a more serious problem.

Question

Are colostomy bags free on the NHS?

Community Answer

Yes, you can set up regular deliveries.

Question

Do you have to measure the stomach size for each time you replace it, and does it change size?

Community Answer

Yes, the stoma will change size within 4 to 8 weeks after the surgery. In that time, you have to measure the stoma when it's time to change the bag. A couple of months after that, the stoma will remain the same size and will not need further measuring.

Question

What if the ostomy patient has a deep stomach crease that prevents the base plate from adhering to their skin and paste/seals don't work?

Community Answer

You need to put the patient in the best and most appropriate possible position. A 45-degree angle is advised.

Question

What can I do if the skin around my stoma has a rash and it burns and stings?

Community Answer

Consult with your doctor. When this happened to my husband, I was advised to use the stoma powder. Gently rub.

Question

Can I print this article?

Community Answer

Yes, there is nothing wrong with printing it.

Question

How do I fasten the clip so it closes the bags and doesn't leak?

Community Answer

Fold the mouthpiece three times, push in the velcro and use a strong paper clip.

Question

Can I wear something to bed over the bag so I don't have an accident?

Community Answer

Yes. It is a closed system so you won't be blocking anything.

Question

How often does the bag need to be changed?

Community Answer

Question**How long does it take for the doctor to insert a colostomy bag?****Community Answer**

Its varies based on why you need it to begin with (intestinal cancer vs. colitis, etc.). Generally, surgery takes anywhere from 2 to 6 hours.

Tips

- Often times, the stoma size can be precut to avoid any excess time being spent on measurement during the removal and exchange of appliance.
- A two-piece drainable system allows for frequent replacement of the actual bag, yet the baseplate only needs to be replaced once or twice weekly. While you can change the colostomy bag whenever you want, most people who have colostomies choose to change it after a bowel movement.

References

1. <https://www.nlm.nih.gov/medlineplus/ency/patientinstructions/000204.htm>
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